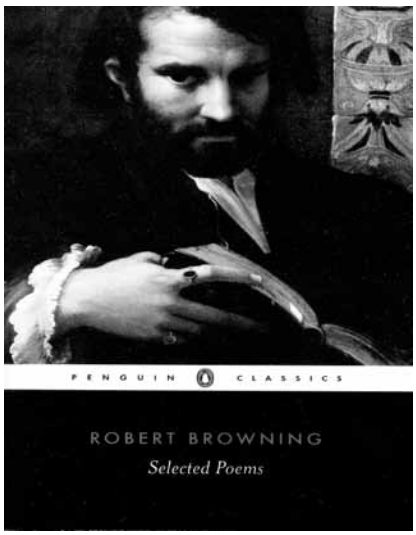
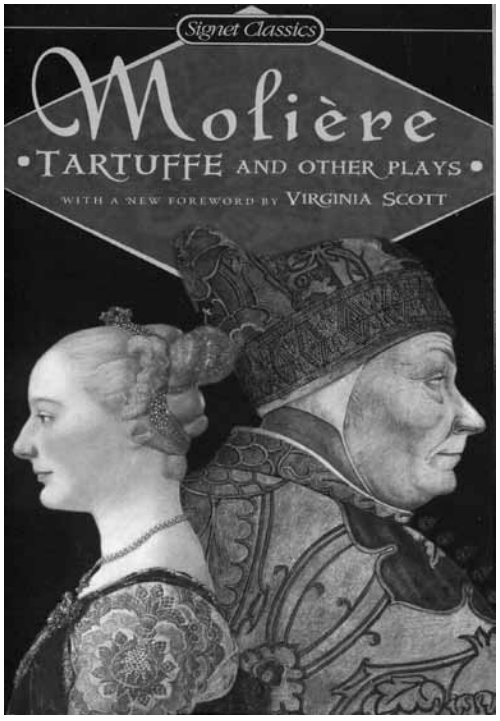
UNIVERSITY INTERSCHOLASTIC LEAGUE

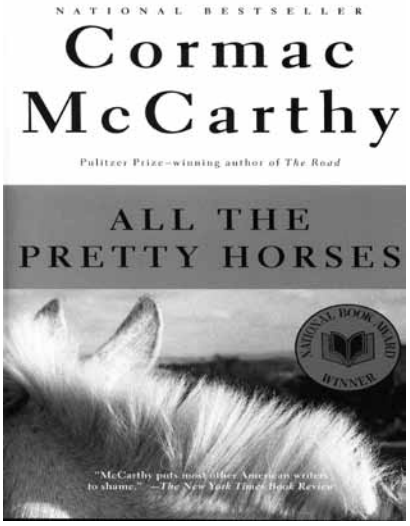
Making a World of Difference

Literary Criticism

District 2 • 2014







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University Interscholastic League
Literary Criticism Contest • District 2 • 2014

Part 1: Knowledge of Literary Terms and of Literary History **30 items (1 point each)**

1. A statement that although seemingly contradictory or absurd may be well founded or true is a(n)
   A) antiphrasis.
   B) equivoque.
   C) oxymoron.
   D) paradox.
   E) paraleipsis.

2. A term applied in general to the things English and in particular to the English royal court during the second quarter of the seventeenth century, a general term that can encompass both Cavalier and Puritan literary expression is
   A) Augustine.
   B) Caroline.
   C) Edwardian.
   D) Jacobean.
   E) Victorian.

3. In modern use, any poem about a rural setting and people that adheres to the genre's original sense and includes "shepherds" of some kind is a
   A) *chanson de geste*.
   B) elegy.
   C) jeremiad.
   D) madrigal.
   E) pastoral.

4. The eighteenth-century Irish novelist, dramatist, and poet who wrote *The Vicar of Wakefield*, *She Stoops to Conquer*, and *The Deserted Village* is
   A) Oliver Goldsmith.
   B) C. S. Lewis.
   C) Bram Stoker.
   D) Jonathan Swift.
   E) William Butler Yeats.

5. The period of American literature in which Anne Bradstreet, Benjamin Franklin, and Jonathan Edwards flourished as authors is called the
   A) Colonial Period.
   B) Postmodern Period.
   C) Realistic Period.
   D) Revolutionary and Early National Period.
   E) Romantic Period.

6. **Not** a type of poetry whose origins can be traced back to the Greeks is (the)
   A) arcadian verse.
   B) bucolic verse.
   C) idyll.
   D) jeremiad.
   E) pastoral.

7. One of the several founders of the critical movement known as New Criticism, the Southern critic, Pulitzer Prize-winning poet, and recipient of the 1947 Pulitzer Prize for Fiction for his *roman à clef* entitled *All the King's Men* is
   A) William Faulkner.
   B) Ernest Hemingway.
   C) John Steinbeck.
   D) John Updike.
   E) Robert Penn Warren.

8. A composition written as though intended to be sung out of doors at night under a window and in praise of a loved one is a(n)
   A) aubade.
   B) ballad.
   C) charm.
   D) lament.
   E) serenade.

9. The revival of emotional religion during the first half of the eighteenth century in America is known as
   A) the Great Awakening.
   B) the Harlem Renaissance.
   C) philistinism.
   D) transcendentalism.
   E) vorticism.

10. The eighteenth-century American author of *Experiments and Observations in Electricity*, *Poor Richard's Almanac*, and *Silence Dogood* is
    A) Jonathan Edwards.
    B) Ben Franklin.
    C) Philip Freneau.
    D) Thomas Jefferson.
    E) John Winthrop.

11. The continuation of the sense and grammatical construction of a line from one verse or couplet on to the next verse or couplet is

A) boustrophedon.
B) enjambment.
C) fused rhyme.
D) run-on line.
E) tag-line.

12. The impressionist dramatist and novelist whose work is recognized as deeply influential on the Theatre of the Absurd and who received the 1934 Nobel Prize for Literature is

A) Giosuè Carducci.
B) Grazia Deledda.
C) Eugenio Montale.
D) Luigi Pirandello.
E) Salvatore Quasimodo.

13. **Not** one of the five elements of the technical structure of a serious play, also known as a play's dramatic structure, is

A) catastrophe.
B) climax.
C) falling action.
D) introduction.
E) peripety.

14. The club of literary and scientific people in and around Boston in the mid-nineteenth century who came together at irregular intervals chiefly for social intercourse and good conversation is the

A) Saturday Club.
B) Sunday Club.
C) Thursday Club.
D) Tuesday Club.
E) Wednesday Club.

15. A composition, usually verse, arranged in such a way that it spells words, phrases, or sentences when certain letters are selected according to an orderly sequence is an

A) abecedarius.
B) acrostic.
C) anagram.
D) ananym.
E) aphorism.

16. The modern movement in politics, economics, and all the arts that, in literature, is characterized by brevity, economy, and modesty, is

A) aestheticism.
B) hermeticism.
C) impressionism.
D) minimalism.
E) surrealism.

17. A type of easily understood tale popular in medieval France whose characters are always human and whose mode is always humorous, sly satire is the

A) epic.
B) fable.
C) *fabliau*.
D) legend.
E) saga.

18. The currently influential African American poet and recipient of the 1994 Pulitzer Prize for Poetry for his collection *Neon Vernacular* is

A) James Baldwin.
B) Alex Haley.
C) Yusef Komunyakaa.
D) August Wilson.
E) Richard Wright.

19. The figure of speech that seeks, by tapping into the knowledge and memory of the reader, to secure a resonant emotional effect from the associations already existing in the reader's mind is

A) allusion.
B) influence.
C) milieu.
D) mimesis.
E) résumé.

20. The absurdist and experimental playwright who is the recipient of the 1967, the 1975, and the 1994 Pulitzer Prizes for Drama, the latter for *Three Tall Women*, is

A) Edward Albee.
B) Horton Foote.
C) David Mamet.
D) Neil Simon.
E) Tennessee Williams.

21. The belief that everything partakes of a hierarchical system, extending upward from inanimate matter to man, to angels, to God, is known as (the)

A) animism.
B) deism.
C) Great Chain of Being.
D) hieronymy.
E) pantheism.

22. A form of drama, largely Senecan in inspiration and technique, made popular on the Elizabethan stage by Thomas Kyd and William Shakespeare, among others, is

A) chronicle play.
B) comedy.
C) Menippean satire.
D) revenge tragedy.
E) tragicomedy.

23. A sequence that "thickens" as it moves toward its end, each word a syllable longer than the preceding word, is called

A) grotesque.
B) macabre.
C) proleptic.
D) rhopalic.
E) uncial.

24. The twentieth-century American multi-award-winning author of *Accordion Crimes* and "The Half-Skinned Steer," as well as *The Shipping News* (1994 Pulitzer) and "Brokeback Mountain," both of which have been made into acclaimed motion pictures, is

A) Gwendolyn Brooks.
B) Lillian Hellman.
C) Harper Lee.
D) Toni Morrison.
E) E. Annie Proulx.

25. The connotatively derogatory term that has been used contemptuously to characterize the "tribe" of bad writers and hacks living in central London is

A) Angry Young Men.
B) Grub Street.
C) Martian School.
D) Spasmodics.
E) Young Men from the Provinces.

26. The form of verse to be sung or recited and characterized by its presentation of a dramatic or exciting episode in simple narrative form is the

A) aubade.
B) ballad.
C) madrigal.
D) requiem.
E) rondeau.

27. The group of Renaissance writers who favored the introduction of heavy Latin and Greek words into the standard English vocabulary is known as the

A) Ciceronians.
B) Geneva School.
C) Inkhornists.
D) Parnassians.
E) *Pléiade*.

28. **Not** among the nineteenth-century and twentieth-century anglophone poets who wrote dramatic monologues is

A) Matthew Arnold.
B) Robert Browning.
C) Geoffrey Chaucer.
D) T. S. Eliot.
E) Alfred, Lord Tennyson.

29. The philosophical movement originating in Europe and reaching the United States during the nineteenth century that features a reliance on both intuition and the conscience in artistic thought is

A) existentialism.
B) philistinism.
C) pictorialism.
D) surrealism.
E) transcendentalism.

30. The trope in which occurs a substitution of the name of an object closely associated with a word for the word itself is

A) ambiguity.
B) hypallage.
C) metonymy.
D) onomatopoeia.
E) synecdoche.

Part 2: The UIL Reading List **20 items (2 points each)**

Items 31-36 are associated with Molière's *Tartuffe, or The Impostor.*
Items 37-43 are associated with Cormac McCarthy's *All the Pretty Horses.*
Items 44-50 are associated with Robert Browning's poetry (selected).

31. The opening act of Molière's *Tartuffe* finds Dorine detailing the health conditions of
    A) Elmire and Tartuffe.
    B) Mariane and Tatuffe.
    C) Orgon and Tartuffe.
    D) Pernelle and Tartuffe.
    E) Valère and Tartuffe.

32. The tone characterizing Orgon's response to Cléante's level-headed advice, "Oh yes, you are a learned sage, I know; / The sapience of the world within you lies; / You alone are enlightened, truly wise," is
    A) amiable.
    B) belligerent.
    C) compassionate.
    D) outraged.
    E) sarcastic.

33. The cautioned, troubled concern, "Am I to watch you seek another's arms / And not console my heart with other charms?" is shared by
    A) Tartuffe with Elmire.
    B) Tartuffe with Mariane.
    C) Valère with Dorine.
    D) Valère with Elmire.
    E) Valère with Mariane.

34. The balanced, if misplaced, optimism of the advisory, "Please moderate your anger if you can: / Your father's only talked about this plan. / Not all that men propose becomes fact," is
    A) Dorine's advice to Cléante.
    B) Dorine's advice to Damis.
    C) Dorine's advice to Elmire.
    D) Dorine's advice to Flipote.
    E) Dorine's advice to Mariane.

35. "Beware of false suspicions. / Good can seem evil under some conditions" characterizes the persistent loyalty to Tartuffe of
    A) Laurent.
    B) Monsieur Loyal.
    C) Madame Pernelle.
    D) Orgon.
    E) Valère.

36. "Can it be that such a pious face / Conceals a heart so false, a soul so base" encapsulates
    A) Elmire's exasperation.
    B) Dorine's wariness.
    C) Orgon's epiphany.
    D) Pernelle's allegiance.
    E) Valère's impatience.

37. In Cormac McCarthy's *All the Pretty Horses* the observation that "[s]cars have the strange power to remind us that our past is real" is offered to John Cole in a conversation with
    A) Alejandra.
    B) Alfonsa.
    C) Franklin.
    D) Perez.
    E) Rawlins.

38. Blevins tells Rawlins, "[D]ont be spittin in the fire where I got supper cookin." Supper that night is
    A) antelope.
    B) jackrabbit.
    C) mountain oysters.
    D) oysters.
    E) rattlesnake.

39. "The country [will] never be the same. People dont feel safe no more. We're like the Comanches was two hundred years ago. We dont know what's goin to show up here come daylight" serves as
    A) Duena Alfonsa's memory-driven lament.
    B) John Grady Cole's final in-saddle soliloquy.
    C) Wayne Cole's minimalist farewell.
    D) Emilio Perez's assessment of the world.
    E) Lacey Rawlins's sobering leave-taking.

40. Blevins, upon being challenged to prove his expertise with his Colt Bisley, shoots, "between the eyes," a photo of
    A) Mary Catherine Barnett.
    B) John Grady Cole.
    C) Lacey Rawlins.
    D) Alejandra Rocha y Villareal.
    E) Betty Ward.

41. The biographical "My father is buried less than two hundred meters from where we sit now. I walk out there often and talk with him. I talk with him as I could never do in life. He made me an exile in my own country" enhances the paradoxical parallel between

A) John Grady and Alfonsa.
B) John Grady and Blevins.
C) John Grady and Don Hector.
D) John Grady and Mary Catherine.
E) John Grady and Rawlins.

42. John Grady shares his story of killing and his desire to kill someone else with a man who understands because of his own circumstances regarding the responsibility for someone's death; the person with whom he shares is

A) the Ecantada captain.
B) the La Purísima *hacendado*.
C) the Ozona judge.
D) the Saltillo *papazote*.
E) the San Angelo lawyer.

43. Pointing out that there is "[n]o evil beyond them," Don Hector recounts that the French came into his house to mutilate his

A) aunt.
B) billiard game.
C) daughter.
D) father's portrait.
E) wife.

Items 44-48 refer to Robert Browning's

Two in the Campagna

I wonder how you feel to-day
As I have felt since, hand in hand,
We sat down on the grass, to stray
In spirit better through the land,
This morn of Rome and May?

For me, I touched a thought, I know,
Has tantalized me many times,
(Like turns of thread the spiders throw
Mocking across our path) for rhymes
To catch at and let go.

Help me to hold it! First it left
The yellow fennel, run to seed
There, branching from the brickwork's cleft,
Some old tomb's ruin: yonder weed
Took up the floating weft,
Where one small orange cup amassed
Five beetles, — blind and green they grope
Among the honey meal: and last,
Everywhere on the grassy slope
O traced it. Hold it fast!

The champaign with its endless fleece
Of feathery grasses everywhere!
Silence and passion, joy and peace,
An everlasting wash of air—
Rome's ghost since her decease.

Such life here, through such lengths of hours,
Such miracles performed in play,
Such primal naked forms of flowers,
Such letting nature have her way
While heaven looks from its towers!

How say you? Let us, O my dove,
Let us be unashamed of soul,
As earth lies bare to heaven above!
How is it under our control
To love or not to love?

I would that you were all to me,
You that are just so much, no more.
Nor yours nor mine, nor slave nor free!
Where does the fault lie? What the core
O' the wound, since wound must be?

I would I could adopt your will,
See with your eyes, and set my heart
Beating by yours, and drink my fill
At your soul's springs, — our part my part
In life, for good and ill.

No. I yearn upward, touch you close,
Then stand away. I kiss your cheek,
Catch your soul's warmth, — I pluck the rose
And love it more than tongue can speak—
Then the good minute goes.

Already how am I so far
Our of that minute? Must I go
Still like the thistle-ball, no bar,
Onward, whenever light winds blow,
Fixed by no friendly star?

Just when I seemed about to learn!
Where is the thread now? Off again!
The Old trick! Only I discern—
Infinite passion, and the pain
Of finite hearts that yearn.

questions on next page

44. In Robert Browning's "Two in the Campagna," the "thought" that "[h]as tantalized" the speaker, "for **rhymes** / To catch and let go" (lines 5-10), suggests that a poet renders thought into poetry; the trope upon which this assessment of poetry turns is

A) hyperbole.
B) litotes.
C) metaphor.
D) paradox.
E) synecdoche.

45. The speaker's immediate relationship with his lover, as expressed in "hand in hand, / We sat down on the grass, to stray / In spirit [. . .]" (lines 2-4) is

A) comical.
B) farcical.
C) melodramatic.
D) paradoxical.
E) saccharine.

46. "Such letting nature have her way / While heaven looks from its towers! / [. . .] / Let us be unashamed of soul / As earth [. . .] / How is it under our control / To love or not to love?" speaks to a union of

A) bodies.
B) both the lovers' bodies and souls.
C) hearts.
D) heaven and earth.
E) nature and heaven.

47. The metric pattern of Browning's "Two in the Campagna" is overwhelmingly

A) anapestic pentameter.
B) choriambic trimeter.
C) dactylic dimeter.
D) iambic tetrameter.
E) trochaic hexameter.

48. The setting of the poem, the *campagna romana* in the spring, suggests, indeed, evokes a sense of

A) barbarism.
B) miasma.
C) pollinosis.
D) romance.
E) tragedy.

Items 49-50 refer to Robert Browning's

Meeting at Midnight

I
The grey sea and the long black land;
And the yellow half-moon large and low;
And the startled little waves that leap
In fiery ringlets from their sleep,
As I gain the cove with pushing prow,
And quench its speed i' the slushy sand.

II
Then a mile of warm sea-scented beach;
Three fields to cross till a farm appears;
A tap at the pane, the quick sharp scratch
And blue spurt of a lighted match,
And a voice less loud, thro' its joys and fears,
Than the two hearts beating each to each!

49. The driving prosodic aesthetic of Browning's "Meeting at Midnight" is

A) disappointment.
B) loss.
C) movement.
D) stasis.
E) transcendence.

50. The natural detail noted by the speaker creates

A) dramatic irony.
B) gallows humor.
C) hyperbole.
D) imagery.
E) syzygy.

Part 3: Ability in Literary Criticism
15 items (2 points each)

Items 51-52 refer to Randall Jarrell's

The Death of the Ball Turret Gunner

From my mother's sleep I fell into the State,
And I hunched in its belly till my wet fur froze.
Six miles from earth, loosed from its dream of life,
I woke to black flak and the nightmare fighters.
When I died they washed me out of the turret with a hose.

questions on next page

51. The opening line of Jarrell's poem speaks of a "falling": "From my mother's sleep I fell into the State [. . .]." If the verb *fell* does allude to the primal fall from innocence to sin, the figurative expression at work is (a/an)

A) ambiguity.
B) hyperbole.
C) oxymoron.
D) pun.
E) symbol.

52. The final line of Jarrell's poem, "When I died they washed me out of the turret with a hose" points, at once subtly and grossly, to state-sponsored violence's

A) coming to an end.
B) defining heroism.
C) required preparedness.
D) seductive martyrdom.
E) uncaring repetitiveness.

Items 53-57 refer to Anthony Hecht's

The End of the Weekend

A dying firelight slides along the quirt* **riding whip**
Of the cast iron cowboy where he leans
Against my father's books. The lariat
Whirls into darkness. My girl in skin tight jeans
Fingers a page of Captain Marryat,*
Inviting insolent shadows to her shirt. 6

We rise together to the second floor.
Outside, across the lake, an endless wind
Whips against the headstones of the dead and wails
In the trees for all who have and have not sinned.
She rubs against me and I feel her nails.
Although we are alone, I lock the door. 12

The eventual shapes of all our formless prayers:
This dark, this cabin of loose imaginings,
Wind, lip, lake, everything awaits
The slow unloosening of her underthings
And then the noise. Something is dropped. It grates
Against the attic beams.
I climb the stairs 18

Armed with a belt.
A long magnesium shaft
Of moonlight from the dormer* cuts a path **part of attic**
Among the shattered skeletons of mice.
A great black presence beats its wings in wrath.
Above the boneyard burn its golden eyes.
Some small grey fur is pulsing in its grip. 24

*** author of sea tales and innovator of a maritime flag code**

53. Lines 8-10 of Hecht's "The End of the Weekend," "an endless wind / [. . .] wails / In the trees for all who have and have not sinned" suggests that the speaker is at a threshold, a moment of

A) kenosis.
B) liminality.
C) metastasis.
D) negative capability.
E) open-endedness.

54. The title of the poem, "The End of the Weekend" depends, in part, on the emotional implications associated with *weekend*; this is its

A) connotation.
B) definition.
C) denotation.
D) exposition.
E) paradox.

55. Lines 13-16, "The eventual shapes of all our formless prayers: / This dark, this cabin of loose imaginings, / Wind, lip, lake, everything awaits / The slow unloosening of her underthings," speak to a(n)

A) aggressiveness.
B) carelessness.
C) discontinuing.
D) expectancy.
E) turmoil.

56. The significant visual aspect of lines 18 and 19 emphasize the poet's use of

A) boustrophedon.
B) end-stopped lines.
C) enjambment.
D) metaplasm.
E) truncation.

57. The "great black presence beat[ing] its wings in wrath" (line 22) is a cross-cultural

A) allegory.
B) emblem.
C) hyperbole.
D) riddle.
E) symbol.

Items 58-60 refer to Helen Chasin's

City Pigeons

Old people are like birds:
the same words flock to the mind's eye
in speaking of them.
They perch in public places,
scratch for the world's crumbs, seek
its shiny trifles—
easily ruffled
are quick to realight, alert
and nodding,
cheeky occupants of plazas,
monuments' companions, supplicants
in lime-specked groves
to dirty mysteries.

58. The figurative comparison that dominates Chasin's "City Pigeons" is called its

A) controlling image.
B) emblem.
C) epigram.
D) epiphany.
E) objective correlative.

59. The trope within the poem itself that sets up the comparison that continues through the poem is a

A) conceit.
B) metaphor.
C) metonymy.
D) pun.
E) simile.

60. The internal compound rhyme of line 8 depends on

A) alliteration.
B) assonance.
C) consonance.
D) dissonance.
E) sigmatism.

Items 61-65 refer to William Shakespeare's

Sonnet 29

When, in disgrace with Fortune and men's eyes,
I all alone beweep my outcast state,
And trouble deaf heaven with my bootless* cries,
And look upon myself and curse my fate,
Wishing me like to one more rich in hope,
Featured like him, like him with friends possessed,
Desiring this man's art, and that man's scope,
With what I most enjoy contented least;
Yet in these thoughts myself almost despising,
Haply I think on thee, and then my state,
Like to the lark at break of day arising
From sullen earth sings hymns at heaven's gate;
For thy sweet love remembered such wealth brings,
That then I scorn to change my state with kings.

*** useless**

61. The treatment that Fortune receives in the first line of Shakespeare's Sonnet 29 is

A) allegory.
B) apostrophe.
C) humanism.
D) personification.
E) subjectivity.

62. The two phrases "featured like him, like him with friends possessed" (line 6) and line 8's "most enjoy contented least" are examples of

A) chiasmus.
B) dieresis.
C) elision.
D) parallelism.
E) zeugma.

63. The speaker's use of "state" to mean both his emotional state and, metonymically, his throne (his condition in life) constitutes a(n)

A) cliché.
B) double entendre.
C) oxymoron.
D) pun.
E) understatement.

64. The tone of the first two quatrains, especially line 3, is

A) despairing.
B) flippant.
C) patronizing.
D) reverent.
E) wrathful.

65. The sonnet's volta, its turn in thought, occurs at

A) line 5.
B) line 9.
C) line 10.
D) line 12.
E) line 13.

Part 4: Tie-Breaking Essay (required)

Note well: Contestants who do not write an essay will be disqualified even if they are not involved in any tie.

Note well: Any essay that does not demonstrate a sincere effort to discuss the assigned topic will be disqualified. The judge(s) should note carefully this criterion when breaking ties: ranking of essays for tie-breaking purposes should be based primarily on how well the topic has been addressed.

Three sheets of paper have been provided for this essay; your written response should reflect the *Handbook*'s notion that an essay is a "moderately brief discussion of a restricted topic": something more than just a few sentences.

Read Robert Browning's "Verse-Making Was Least of My Virtues," and address the persona's contrasting of verse-making to love-making. (***Please*** note the comment that addresses the meaning of love-making that follows the poem.)

Verse-Making Was Least of My Virtues

Verse-making was least of my virtues: I viewed with despair
Wealth that never yet was but might be—all that verse-making were
If the life would but lengthen to wish, let the mind be laid bare.
So I said, "To do little is bad, to do nothing is worse"—
And made verse.

Love-making,—how simple a matter! No depths to explore,
No heights in a life to ascend! No disheartening Before,
No affrighting Hereafter,—love now will be love ever more.
So I felt "To keep silence were folly:"—all language above,
I made love.*

***simply "I courted her"**
to court: to try to gain the love or affections of
---
the phrase "to make love" did not pick up its sexual connotation until mid-twentieth century

KEY

UIL Literary Criticism
District 2 • 2014

line arrows up ➔

1.	D	349
2.	B	75
3.	E	354
4.	A	548
5.	A	96
6.	D	261
7.	E	602
8.	E	440
9.	A	47
10.	B	545
11.	B	174
12.	D	599
13.	E	360
14.	A	429
15.	B	4
16.	D	300
17.	C	192
18.	C	605
19.	A	14
20.	A	608
21.	C	222
22.	D	409
23.	D	413
24.	E	603
25.	B	224
26.	B	49
27.	C	253
28.	C	
29.	E	483
30.	C	298
31.	A	1.4.231
32.	E	
33.	E	2.4.739
34.	B	3.1.827
35.	C	5.3.1681
36.	C	5.2.1601
37.	B	135
38.	B	62
39.	C	25
40.	E	55
41.	A	239
42.	C	290
43.	B	146
44.	E	470
45.	D	349
46.	B	
47.	D	
48.	D	
49.	C	
50.	D	246
51.	A	17
52.	E	
53.	B	273
54.	A	107
55.	D	
56.	C	174
57.	E	
58.	A	108
59.	E	445
60.	C	107
61.	D	361
62.	A	84
63.	D	390
64.	A	
65.	B	498

FOLD along the **three** longitudinal lines for ease in grading. ➔

Please note that the objective scores should not be altered to reflect the breaking of any ties. ***Simply adjust ranking***.

The thirty items in Part 1 are worth one point each.

The twenty items in Part 2 are worth two points each.

The fifteen items in Part 3 are worth two points each.

DO NOT
mark (cross out)
actual **LETTER** answer;
mark the answer **NUMERAL**.

Page numbers refer to the *Handbook* 12e,

to the Signet *Tartuffe*,

to the Vintage *Pretty*,

and to Penguin's Browning collection.

Part 4: Tie-Breaking Essay

These notes are not intended to be understood as a key for the Tie-Breaking Essay prompt; rather, they should serve the judge(s) as a presentation of critical ideas that might appear in an essay responding to the prompt.

Criteria for judging the Tie-Breaking Essay **SHOULD** include

the degree to which the instructions have been followed,

the quality of the critical insight offered in response to the selection,

the overall effectiveness of the written discussion, and

the grammatical correctness of the essay.

Note well that the quality of the contestant's critical insight is more important than the contestant's prose style. In short, the Literary Criticism contest is one that promotes the critical analysis of literature. The quality of the writing, which should never go unappreciated, does not trump evidence of critical analysis.

Critical Notes on Robert Browning's "Verse-Making Was Least of My Virtues"

Literary concepts that **MIGHT** be used in a discussion of the persona's revealing of himself in Browning's "Verse-Making Was Least of My Virtues" include

abstract,
aphorism,
character,
cliché,
conceit,
concrete,
consonance,
irony,
rhyme scheme, and
tone.

The young writer should recognize that a comparison of writing poetry to courting a woman might have a few points of comparison, but the poem's persona is dwelling on what he perceives to be a significant set of differences. The contestant might address the tone of the persona's listing of these differences, the principle difference being the simplicity of love-making* in contrast to verse-writing.

The contestant might recognize in the persona's argument that courting a woman is easier than writing verse, an irony that points to his apparent failing to establish a long-term commitment. While writing poetry is indeed difficult—and he does admit to its being among the least of his virtues, he approaches the task with pragmatism, as settled in the aphoristic "To do little is bad, to do nothing is worse." The persona's second turn to aphorism, "To keep silence were folly," seems to put an easily attained goal Before the difficult journey described in the first stanza.

A further answer irony might be argued: the persona-as-poet will not "keep silence" (line 13) in his pursuit of love, apparently either without concern for the quality of the language or, perhaps, in a high self-estimation, his love-language never fails, and he never, apparently views this particular species of effort with despair, as he does verse-making (line1). One suspects that during the nineteenth-century love-making without language would have gotten he-who-would-woo nowhere, for language is often the vehicle by which affection is initialized. In short, the persona has unwittingly (or wittingly) revealed that he thinks that he is much better at courtship than at the writing of poetry, something at which he must actually work—especially if the poet wishes to write poetry that doesn't turn on cliché's.

*** the phrase "to make love" did not pick up its sexual connotation until mid-twentieth century**